

Photographs by RANJAN RAHII



(ABOVE) NEO-SIKHS AT THE GURDWARA IN HALHALIA AND VILLAGE PRIEST AMLANAND RISHIDEV (BELOW)



(eating and worshipping together) to bridge the social divide. Besides, everyone is free to practise a religion of his choice," he says.

Caste imbalances, discrimination and power play have remained central to Bihar society though the politics of social justice and the politicians preaching it have made significant gains over the years. Notwithstanding the laws banning discrimination, caste violence occurs at regular intervals in the state. Police records suggest that the number of atrocities against Scheduled Castes (scs) and Scheduled Tribes (sts) hasn't gone down despite Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's claims. It's the Government's affirmative action (read job reservation) policy for scs and sts that has, to an extent, improved their social status and economic conditions. This has also forced many Dalits in this village, who are still categorised as scs in government records, to retain this tag in

order to avail the quota facility and get a government job. Like Narender's brother, Birender Singh, 40, one of the three graduates from this village, says, "We are at the lowest rank in Hindu society. Education and this sc status will ensure jobs and help us climb the social ladder." On the other hand, Vinod Singh and Manish Singh, who also converted to Sikhism, think otherwise. "We are Sikhs, a minority, and the Government must acknowledge us as part of the minority community," they say in unison.

Though a majority of Halhalia's populace is yet to adopt Sikhism, the spin-offs of these conversions have redefined social norms in the area. Many villagers have stopped drinking alcohol or eating rats. "Alcoholism is perhaps the single most important reason that prevents the Mushahars from entering the mainstream of the society," admits Dalit activist Sudha Verghese. "While these people have the freedom to adopt whichever religion they want, it is good to see Dalits shunning alcoholism after becoming Sikhs," she told INDIA TODAY. "Sikhism has brought us back to light that was enveloped in darkness caused by alcoholism," says 30-year-old Sardar Vinod Singh Rishidev. His wife Sabita Kaur agrees: "There were drunken brawls every night. Men used to return home drunk after spending their day's earnings on liquor and toddy, and the children had to go to bed hungry. Things have changed now and even the non-Sikhs in the village prefer to abstain."

These conversions have, however, not evoked any negative reaction since many believe Sikhism to be an extension of Hinduism. Singh Sahib Gyani Ekbaal Singh, the Jathedar of Takht Sri Harimandirji, Patna Saheb, says, "The Sikh religion is not against anyone and nobody has been proselytising these Dalits. All these conversions have been voluntary. I am glad when people gravitate towards the teachings of the gurus." For these former Dalits, it's not just a change of faith but a change to make their lives better. ■